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PRESS RELEASE

Continuation of the Programme for Provision of Relief to People Affected by the War Situation in the Middle East

The Cabinet of Ministers, at its meeting held on 28-09-2026, approved the continuation of the Programme for Provision of Relief to People Affected by the War Situation in the Middle East, as set out below.

In response to the impact of the prevailing war situation in the Middle East, which has resulted in an increase in global petroleum prices, the Government has incurred an expenditure of over Rs. 105 billion to implement measures aimed at mitigating the impact on the day-to-day lives of the people and the overall economy of the country.

Under this programme, measures were taken to provide a subsidy of Rs. 100 per litre of diesel and Rs. 20 per litre of petrol during April, May and June 2026, with a view to maintaining domestic fuel prices at an affordable level for consumers.

In addition, measures have already been taken to provide relief through an additional allowance to Aswesuma beneficiaries in April, providing relief to electricity consumers, increasing the fertilizer subsidy provided to farmers for the Yala season, and implementing a subsidy scheme for the fisheries sector.

As the war situation prevailing in the Middle East region has not yet ended, continued Government intervention has become essential to mitigate its impact on the lives of the people of the country.

Accordingly, the Government has decided to provide a temporary subsidy exclusively for Auto Diesel excluding Super Diesel for public transportation in the country for the months of October, November and December 2026. The subsidy for diesel will be provided subject to a maximum of Rs. 15 billion in October, Rs. 13.5 billion in November and Rs. 12.15 billion in December. After the October 1st increase, fuel prices will continue to be revised to partly reflect international price movements and will not be reduced in November or December while the subsidy is being provided. The 2027 Budget does not provide for new fuel subsidy spending, except for the settlement in 2027 of fuel subsidy obligations incurred in financial year 2026.

Further, targeted cash transfers to families receiving Aswesuma benefits are expected to be increased through additional top up. Accordingly, taking into consideration the time required to make the necessary arrangements for an additional payment under the Aswesuma Programme, an additional allowance of Rs. 3,000 for the month of November and a further Rs. 3,250 for December per family unit in the "Extremely Poor" category, and an additional allowance of Rs. 2,000 for November and a further Rs. 2,000 for December per family unit in the "Poor" category are planned to be provided. To this end, an additional allocation of Rs. 6 billion will be required.

In providing all these facilities, the Government is expected to incur an estimated expenditure of Rs. 47 billion, to be financed through adjustments to provisions within the expenditure ceiling approved under the 2026 Budget.